

An Autistic Colleague at Work

For colleagues, managers & employers — working alongside an autistic adult.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a colleague's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." In the right environment that's a genuine asset — sustained concentration, reliability, depth, pattern-detection and honesty. In the wrong one (open-plan noise, constant interruption, office politics, vague expectations) it drives masking and **autistic burnout**. Most accommodations that help an autistic colleague — clarity, predictability, fewer interruptions, written communication — make the workplace better for everyone. You don't need to be an expert; curiosity and small adjustments go a long way.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Deep, focused work; dislikes meetings & chatter	Monotropic focus — a strength; protect it
Wants emails over calls; takes things literally	Single-channel, literal communication — not awkwardness
Exhausted, withdrawn, or "off" after high-social days	Heavy masking ; the cost is paid later
Misses unwritten rules or office politics	Not "playing the game" — genuinely doesn't see those channels
Loyal, reliable, bluntly honest	Often the colleague who spots the problem no one else named

Try this

- **Be clear and explicit** — written briefs, defined deadlines, named expectations; say the "unwritten rules."
- **Protect focus** — fewer interruptions, fewer meetings, asynchronous options, a quieter spot.
- **Give literal, kind feedback** — say what you mean; assume good intent in blunt exchanges.
- **Make social optional** — don't make team belonging depend on the pub or loud events.
- **Ask what helps** — the person is the expert; reasonable adjustments (Equality Act / ADA) are a right.

Avoid this

- Vague briefs, last-minute changes, or surprise "quick chats."
- Equating eye contact, small talk or "visibility" with commitment or competence.
- Reading a burnout withdrawal as "not a team player."

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** (chronic exhaustion, loss of skills, reduced tolerance) — it's linked to suicidality and is distinct from ordinary work stress. Reasonable adjustments, reduced load or time off are recovery, not weakness. Signpost occupational health, employee assistance and autistic-led workplace resources.

If your colleague is a woman

Late-diagnosed women mask most heavily and may look “high-performing” while privately exhausted; take overload and a request for adjustments seriously, regardless of how together they seem.

About this guide

AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4), the **Family guide** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Knight (2021, *tunnels not tasks*); Booth (2021, work & autistic people); Raymaker et al. (2020); Mantzalas et al. (2022). Full citations are in the source drafts.